



N. Sudarshan

sudarshan.narayanan@thehindu.co.in

The strength of the Ranji Trophy can be gauged by the fact that the nine editions preceding 2025-26 were won by five different teams. Of these, four were first-time winners. It is also a tough competition to win because it requires months-long excellence, adaptability to different pitches and weather conditions, and above all, supreme fitness.

In October 2025, only a very brave man would have picked Jammu & Kashmir to win the title. But Paras Dogra and his band of merry men upset the cricketing hierarchy and disregarded pedigree to clinch its maiden domestic red-ball crown. Coming as it did after the reverse to Kerala in last season's quarterfinals, when

Final scorecard



Jammu & Kashmir

1st innings: 584 (Pundir 121, Yawer 88, Prasidh 5-98)

2nd innings: 342 for 4 decl. (Iqbal 160*, Lotra 101, Prasidh 2-42)

Karnataka

1st innings: 293 (Agarwal 160, Nabi 5-54)

J&K won on first-innings lead

the southern side progressed via a narrow one-run first-innings lead, the success was sweeter.

J&K registered outright wins over five former champions — Rajasthan, Delhi, Hyderabad, Madhya Pradesh and Bengal. In the final in Hubballi, it outclassed eight-time champion Karnataka by securing a massive 291-run first-innings lead and then grinding the star-studded outfit, comprising the likes of K.L. Rahul, Karun Nair, Mayank Agarwal and Devdutt Padikkal, into an unrecognisable pile of dust.

"I never thought that we could win the Ranji Trophy," said coach Ajay Sharma immediately after the triumph. "It's a proud moment for the team and all the people of Jammu & Kashmir. We beat so many former champions with a lot of experience and Test cricketers. We had no hero. Now, everybody is a hero."

Chief among them was pacer Auqib Nabi, who took a tournament-high 60 wickets at an average of 12.56 and a scarcely believable strike-rate of 28.43. There were seven five-wicket hauls, and four of those came in the knockouts, as Nabi finished with a whopping 104 Ranji Trophy wickets across the last two seasons combined.

The 29-year-old's performance versus Karnataka was the acme as he bowled a deadly five-over spell on